

macOS Terminal

The macOS-specific commands — pbcopy, open, mdfind, defaults, and Homebrew.

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macOS-only Commands ▼

macOS ships a BSD-flavoured Unix userland, so the usual `cd`, `ls`, and `grep` all work. This sheet focuses on the commands that are unique to macOS — the ones worth knowing beyond generic Linux.

MACOS-ONLY COMMANDS

COMMAND	ACTION
<code>open .</code>	open the current folder in Finder
<code>open file.pdf</code>	open a file with its default app
<code>open -a Safari url</code>	open with a specific app
<code>pbcopy < file</code>	copy a file's contents to the clipboard
<code>pbpaste > file</code>	paste the clipboard into a file
<code>cmd pbcopy</code>	pipe command output to the clipboard
<code>mdfind name</code>	Spotlight search from the terminal
<code>say 'done'</code>	speak text aloud
<code>caffeinate -d</code>	keep the Mac awake until you Ctrl-C

COMMAND	ACTION
<code>sw_vers</code>	show the macOS version

HOMEBREW

COMMAND	ACTION
<code>brew install <pkg></code>	install a formula
<code>brew install --cask <app></code>	install a GUI app
<code>brew update && brew upgrade</code>	update Homebrew, then all packages
<code>brew list</code>	list installed packages
<code>brew search <term></code>	search for a formula/cask
<code>brew uninstall <pkg></code>	remove a package
<code>brew services start <svc></code>	run a background service
<code>brew doctor</code>	diagnose common problems
<code>brew cleanup</code>	delete old versions and caches

SYSTEM & DEFAULTS

COMMAND	ACTION
<code>softwareupdate -l</code>	list available OS updates
<code>defaults read <domain></code>	read an app's preferences

COMMAND	ACTION
<code>defaults write <domain> <key> <val></code>	change a hidden setting
<code>killall Finder</code>	restart Finder (after defaults changes)
<code>launchctl list</code>	list launchd (background) jobs
<code>pmset -g</code>	show power-management settings
<code>diskutil list</code>	list disks and volumes



defaults write can break apps. Undocumented `defaults` keys are unsupported and can leave an app in a weird state. Note the current value with `defaults read` first so you can put it back.

NETWORKING

COMMAND	ACTION
<code>ifconfig</code>	show network interfaces (BSD-style)
<code>ipconfig getifaddr en0</code>	your current Wi-Fi IP address
<code>networksetup -listallnetworkservices</code>	list network services
<code>scutil --dns</code>	show the resolver / DNS configuration
<code>ping -c 4 host</code>	send 4 probes
<code>arp -a</code>	show the local ARP cache

